

plants, including aubretias, saxifrages, and violas. Add to these a selection of bulbs and corms, starting with snowdrops (*Galanthus*) in late winter or early spring, and followed by crocuses, grape hyacinths (*Muscari*), daffodils (*Narcissus*), and tulips (*Tulipa*). As the majority of these bold displays of bulbs die down, they are followed by spring-flowering azaleas and rhododendrons which provide a wealth of colors, including magenta, pink, crimson, scarlet, golden yellow, and white. As the new leaves unfurl in late spring, blue ceanothus and the scented flowers of viburnums and lilacs enhance the spring garden further.

## Summer

As temperatures rise and light levels increase, the garden is filled with a profusion of perennials, annuals, and biennials. Not many trees put on their best performance in summer, but shrubs are a key source of color. Roses start to bloom early in the season, many continuing well into fall. Other beautiful summer-flowering shrubs include sweetly scented mock oranges (*Philadelphus*), lavender, hibiscus, and the flowering dogwoods (*Cornus*). Even those that flowered in spring still play their part by providing a leafy backdrop to the flowers that offer the main show at this time of year.

Many climbers are also in full swing in summer. There are a vast number of clematis species and hybrids to choose

from, providing color in the garden from early summer to late in the season, while jasmine, honeysuckle, and the frothy flat heads of climbing hydrangea (*Hydrangea petiolaris*) are other star performers.

Perennials are the real stars of the summer border. There are thousands to choose from, including early summer-flowering aquilegias, and many geraniums and lupins, followed by campanulas, salvias, achilleas, and hemerocallis, with heleniums, rudbeckias, and echinaceas appearing later in the season. Biennials, such as foxgloves, make great partners for shade-loving perennials, while hardy and half hardy annuals produce an explosion of color in borders and container displays.

Hardy annuals, such as Californian poppies (*Eschscholzia californica*), annual mallows (*Malope*), and the shoo-fly plant (*Nicandra*) flower for months on end, offering great value for money, and self-seeding to produce a repeat performance the following summer. Together with half-hardy annuals, like cosmos, impatiens, lobelia, and petunias, they provide color throughout the season, often only ceasing to flower when the frosts arrive in fall.

## Fall

As summer fades, the foliage of many trees and shrubs flares into the fiery colors of fall. Some of the best choices for this seasonal display are maples, some cherries, amelanchiers, liquidambars, cotoneasters,

sorbus, nyssa, and most forms of smoke bush (*Cotinus*).

Late-flowering perennials, such as Michaelmas daisies (*Symphyotrichum*) and chrysanthemums, as well as dahlias with their rich variety of flower shapes and colors, brighten up the garden until the arrival of the first frosts. Grasses are also key features of these cooler months. Pampas grasses (*Cortaderia*), fountain grasses (*Pennisetum*), and *Stipa calamagrostis* produce feather- and brush-like seedheads at this time of the year.

## Winter

During winter, flower interest is limited, but valuable sources include the scented blooms of winter box (*Sarcococca*) and witch hazels (*Hamamelis*). Bold sculptural shapes and foliage color provided by evergreens is of most importance now, with conifers, boxwood (*Buxus*), and ivy (*Hedera*), coming into their own.

Deciduous trees and shrubs also play an important role, their intricate skeletons of stems clearly visible at this time of year. Think, too, about bark color and texture; white-stemmed birches (*Betula*) and the polished coppery-brown stems of *Prunus serrula* are favorite trees, while brightly colored dogwood (*Cornus*) and willow (*Salix*) stems make exciting focal points. Enhance the winter scene further with berried shrubs, such as hollies (*Ilex*), pyracanthas, and sorbus.



### Summer profusion

Perennials often lead the border chorus at this time of year. Crocosomias and veronicastrums provide color and form, with the pinky-purple domes of stately eupatoriums offering background color.



### Fall brights

Most perennials die down at this time of year, but a few leave their best performance till last. Hylotelephiums, asters, and symphyotrichums are key features of fall borders, here offset by buff grasses and red-leaved *Euonymus alata*.



### Frosted features

Winter is a quiet time in the garden, but there is still beauty to be found in the form of stark borders filled with frost-encrusted grasses and the enduring seedheads of perennials such as hylotelephiums and sedums.